

The Rivalry is Ruined

India and Australia are to meet again in October. They really shouldn't bother for another two years.

■ **By Sharda Ugra**

Shortly before the Sydney Test, BCCI announced the venues for a four-Test series against Australia in October 2008. Really, they shouldn't bother. There is not much point in the two nations playing each other for a season or two now. For the first time in a while, it is not even worth looking forward to.

In the last seven years, India and Australia have met five times in bilateral series (including seven ODIs last year), more times than anyone else. It had become the most riveting rivalry in 21st century cricket; the Australians may have been dominant but the Indians were always their most defiant opposition. Before India went on this tour, the Test results since 2001 stood at: four wins each to Australia and India, with three draws from 11 Tests. The rivalry that produced epic, soul-stirring cricket and was the making of many legends, has been pushed over the edge. It will never be the same again.

Not even if ICC's PR machine sets up a photo op of Ricky Ponting and Anil Kumble playing pool and shaking hands with warm smiles. It's too late, the contest has been ruined by the acts of men trying to become bigger than the game they were involved in. Cricketing disgruntlement over bad umpiring turned into personal mistrust over the conduct of fellow players.

How the rest of this Australia tour goes is immaterial but the atmosphere around the next one, if it is played so soon, will be pure poison. The cricketers may move on but India won't forget. Corporate wolves will howl, the excitable in the media will put a sports

contest ahead of news of the deaths of soldiers and farmers; there will be headlines of quasi-war, 'vengeance' and the 'battle for honour'.

India is a gracious country but the return of Australia 10 months from now will bring out its least gracious face. Australia is a country of generous sports fans but its commanding cricket team travels the globe representing them like trash talkers, disrespectful of all opposition. When Australia come to India next, it will take nothing to whip

ment and BCCI and its team must be more categorical about its anti-racism messages overall from now on. Semantic debates about 'monkeys' and 'bastards' are the refuge of lawyers, not athletes and sports administrators.

The Indians know what it feels like to be racially abused. Rahul Dravid was called a 'f*****g kaffir' on air by Allan Donald in 1996. In 2002, Nasser Hussain had allegedly called Mohammed Kaif a 'bus driver' in Durham. Had that incident been made

public by the Indians at the time, the consequences on Hussain, England's first British Asian captain and its most pivotal player can only be imagined.

By pulling out the race card, Ponting has set up his own team for future trouble. Every team puts up with being abused by the Aussies in the name of 'mental disintegration' and empty machismo. Englishmen on Ashes tours speak more and more of being vilified as a 'race', not due to their colour but where they come from. Like India in Durham, Ponting had a choice in Sydney: to move against a prickly opponent or to turn the temperatures down. His choice and conduct have altered the nature of how India and Australia will engage with each other over cricket.

So, a two-year freeze on bilateral India vs Australia cricket may seem excessive and will give the bean counters

clinical depression. But it will be time enough for tempers to cool, for protagonists to change, for life to take its natural course. By then, India may actually be able to field three fit fast bowlers and, who knows, we might even miss the contest. ■

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The contest has been marred by the acts of men trying to become bigger than the game.

the plentiful idiots found in our crowds to launch into offensive chanting against Ponting and Andrew Symonds. Saying "we enjoy the culture" and visiting orphanages is unlikely to impress.

If Harbhajan Singh indeed made a racial slur, he deserves severe punish-